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AI VENDOR EVALUATION

Questions to Ask Any AI Vendor

A quick-reference checklist before you sign anything. Print it and bring it to the demo.

1 Data and security

- [ ] Exactly where does our data live, and who inside your company can access it?
- [ ] Is our data used to train your models, for us or for other customers?
- [ ] What is your SOC 2 or ISO 27001 status, and can we see the actual report?
- [ ] What happens to our data, fully, if we cancel or do not renew?

2 Integration and fit

- [ ] Which of our specific systems does it connect to, by name, not just "supports APIs"?
- [ ] What is the realistic implementation timeline, based on a comparable customer?
- [ ] Who on our side needs to own configuration and ongoing maintenance?
- [ ] What breaks if our team turns over mid-implementation?

3 Model and transparency

- [ ] What models power this, and do we get notice before they change?
- [ ] How does the system handle errors or invented output in practice?
- [ ] Can we see where a given output or recommendation came from?
- [ ] What are the stated limitations you would tell a regulator, not a prospect?

4 Commercial and contract

- [ ] What does pricing look like at our actual scale, not pilot volume?
- [ ] What are the real exit and data-portability terms?
- [ ] Where does lock-in actually happen: data, workflow or integrations?
- [ ] What is excluded from the quoted price that we will meet later?

5 Support and roadmap

- [ ] Who do we actually call when something breaks, and what is the service level?
- [ ] What is on your 12-month roadmap, and how often do you ship breaking changes?
- [ ] Can we talk to a reference customer of similar size, unscripted?

6 Internal readiness

- [ ] Do we have a named owner for this tool after the sale closes?
- [ ] How will we know in 90 days whether this worked?
- [ ] What is our fallback if this vendor does not deliver?

Evaluating more than one vendor?

As part of AI Implementation, we turn these questions into a weighted scorecard and compare every finalist against your real requirements.

Book a strategy call

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